

Major Assignment 1: Poster + Essay

*Advertising a Restoration Play***Overview**

Total points: 100

For this assignment, you will create two connected deliverables:

1. **a digital poster** advertising a Restoration-era play
2. **a 750-900 word essay** explaining your rhetorical and design choices

This project asks you to translate a scholarly historical argument into a creative, public-facing medium, while reflecting critically on the choices involved in that translation. You will be assessed on the rationale behind your design choices, not your graphic design expertise.

Use of AI in this assignment will result in a report of Academic Dishonesty.

This assignment also includes graded and scaffolded prewriting/preparatory checkpoints:

1. Checkpoint A: Poster draft (due Wednesday, 2/11) – **failure to submit results in a 5% deduction**
2. Checkpoint B: Essay draft (due Friday, 2/13) – **failure to submit results in a 5% deduction**
3. Checkpoint C: Peer review (in class Wednesday, 2/18) – **failure to complete results in a 10% deduction**
4. Final submission due: Friday, 2/20 – **late submission results in a 10% deduction per day late until day 9 after which it cannot be submitted**

Deliverables & Submission Format

You will submit:

- One digital poster, created using Adobe Express, Adobe Illustrator, Adobe InDesign, or equivalent software
- One essay (750–900 words + MLA Works Cited) submitted as a .docx file

You will **submit the essay as a .docx file** and you will post the **digital poster as an attachment** in the submission comments.

Deliverable 1: Digital Poster (Creative Translation)

Scenario: Imagine you are a theatre manager in charge of a London playhouse between 1660 and 1699. After a fourteen-year closure of the theatres, the playhouses have recently

reopened. London audiences are slowly coming to terms with a major cultural shift: actresses, who have newly appeared on the public stage, are here to stay.

Your company has acquired a new play by a promising playwright, set to premiere next month. While sets are being built, actors and actresses are rehearsing, and tailors are working on costumes, you are responsible for one crucial task: advertising the production.

Your goal is to create a digital poster that would plausibly advertise this play while reflecting the arguments made by [Gilli Bush-Bailey in the introduction to *Treading the Bawds* \(2006\).](#)

Poster Expectations

Content Requirements

Your digital poster must:

- Reimagine an advertisement for a play produced between 1660 and 1699
- Be designed for an imagined public audience, not an academic one
- Include both text AND image:
 - Text written by you (minimum 20 words)
 - One historical or archival image
- In some way, reflect Bush-Bailey's argument or philosophy about actresses, performance, gender, reputation, or theatrical history
- Include a brief source credit for images and Bush-Bailey

Technical Requirements

Your digital poster must:

- Incorporate the design choices discussed in class (layout, typography, image placement)
- Have a dimension of 36"x48" (can be oriented to landscape or portrait; up to you)
- Ensure text is readable when zoomed in at 100% on a screen
- Have a resolution of 100-300 DPI at full output size to keep images crisp
- While you will not be assessed on artistic perfection, please ensure that the text and image are legible

Please don't worry about creating an exact historical poster! You are to produce a historically informed *reinterpretation* that translates scholarly ideas into visual form.

Please upload the poster as an attachment in the submission comments.

Deliverable 2: Essay (Rhetorical Rationale)

Purpose: The essay explains **what** you did and **why**. While the poster is creative, the essay demonstrates your **academic understanding**, rhetorical awareness, and ability to reflect on media translation.

Essay Expectations:

- Word count: 750-900 words + a separate “Works Cited” page (at the end, formatted in MLA style; not included in word count)
- Introduction:
 - Briefly describe the historical moment and the imagined scenario
 - Introduce Bush-Bailey’s argument and your poster’s intended audience
- Summary:
 - Summarize *only the key arguments* that Bush-Bailey makes in the text
 - Use minimum quotations; instead paraphrase her words appropriately
 - Feel free to draw from your work in [Minor Assignment 1: Summary!](#)
- Analysis of visual design choices
 - Summarize in more detail the particular claim that YOU chose to visualize through your poster
 - How did you translate Bush-Bailey’s ideas into visual and textual form?
 - What did you emphasize, simplify, or leave out?
 - How do your design choices reflect the cultural tensions of Restoration theatre?
- Conclusion & Reflection on Medium
 - How does a poster communicate differently than an academic text?
 - What are the strengths and limits of visual persuasion?
 - What did you learn about theater history, rhetoric, and/or digital composition?
 - What challenges did you encounter?

Note: You may also certainly use any of the other sources we have encountered in class so far, such as this [video](#), this [podcast](#), and this [web article](#) (in *addition* to, *not instead of*, Bush-Bailey; and with appropriate citations).

Please submit the essay as a .docx file here.

Learning Goals

At the end of this assignment, students should be able to:

- Understand and summarize scholarly historical arguments
- Practice rhetorical awareness (audience, purpose, medium)
- Translate academic ideas into creative, public-facing media
- Demonstrate digital literacy through purposeful design
- Reflect critically on the relationship between history, writing, and visual communication

Criteria for Evaluation

Your work will be evaluated based on:

- Accuracy and depth of understanding of Bush-Bailey’s argument
- Effectiveness of the poster as a historical and rhetorical translation (awareness of

audience and medium)

- Thoughtful integration of text and image
- Clarity, organization, and insight in the essay
- Proper MLA citation and academic integrity

Rubric

Total Points: 100	Rating			
Criteria	Excellent	Meets Expectations	Needs Improvement	Missing
Understanding of Bush-Bailey's Argument (25 points)				
Poster: Rhetorical Effectiveness & Creativity (25 points)				
Rhetorical Awareness (Audience, Medium, Purpose) (20 points)				
Essay Organization & Critical Reflection (20 points)				
Citation, Attribution & Technical Requirements (10 points)				